

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Setsubun, Japan

On the last day of winter, people flock to Buddhist temples and Shinto shrines to throw roasted soybeans and chant “Demons out, happiness in.” It’s considered lucky to catch and eat as many beans as your age. These events are supported by entertainers, celebrities, and sumo wrestlers.

Marlborough Wine Festival, New Zealand

The lovely Marlborough wine region of South Island is the largest in New Zealand, and was pivotal in introducing New World Sauvignon Blanc to a grateful Old World. Enjoy tastings and tutorials amid the vines of beautiful Brancott Estate. www.wine-marlborough-festival.co.nz

NORTH AMERICA

Feria del Alegría y el Olivo, Santiago Tulyehualco, Mexico City, Mexico

The sacred Aztec amaranth grain and the Spanish-introduced olive sit side by side in a festival that blends ancient culture with modern ideas. Visitors flock to this historic quarter of the city to taste olives and their oils, munch amaranth cakes and cookies, and watch displays of traditional dance and music.

Portland Seafood and Wine Festival, Oregon, USA

The finest Oregon seafood can be found at this family-oriented event, including lobster, crayfish, and the famous Dungeness crab. There’s also an Oyster Shuck & Swallow Contest, a Celebrity Crab Cracking Contest, cooking demonstrations, and live music. Adults can sample from 50 local wines while the kids enjoy puppet shows and building sandcastles. www.pdxseafoodandwinefestival.com

SOUTH AMERICA

Pisco Sour Day, Lima, Peru

Some say that the pisco sour is as Peruvian as Machu Picchu. Those inclined to agree will lift a glass in Lima on the first

Saturday in February and join in the celebrations for this pisco brandy, lime, egg white, and sugar cocktail, with bartender contests, music, and feasts of traditional Peruvian cuisine.

MARCH

EUROPE

Carnevale di Ivrea, Piedmont, Italy

Imagine thousands of brightly costumed combatants pelting each other with oranges, some in horse-drawn carts, others milling around them in the streets, up to their shins in citrus pulp. Or go to Ivrea on Shrove Tuesday and join in the fun. Huge pots of beans and sausages, cod, and polenta are all served free. Magnificent.

Beer Day, Reykjavík, Iceland

Prohibition in the US lasted 13 years; in Hungary it was only 133 days; but in Iceland beer was banned for 74 years, until March 1, 1989. Not surprisingly, that day became National Beer Day and is celebrated in style in pubs, clubs, and restaurants across the party town of Reykjavík.

Maslenitsa, Russia

Maslenitsa is a lively week-long festival that blends the pagan farewell to winter with the Orthodox preparation for Lent. The focus of the feast is the blini, a Russian pancake, round and golden like the sun, topped with sour cream, smoked salmon, honey, or caviar and washed down with vodka.

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Lamberts Bay Kreeffees, South Africa

Kreeffees is Afrikaans for “crayfish feast,” and crayfish are in abundance at this festival in beautiful Lamberts Bay in the Western Cape. Match your tastings with a glass of Graça, South Africa’s best-selling seafood wine, while watching stunning aerial displays and listening to live music. For the more energetic there is bungee-jumping and even a half-marathon. www.kreeffees.com

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Melbourne Food & Wine Festival, Australia

Possibly the largest extravaganza of its kind, this event boasts more than 250 gastronomic and wine events over ten days, including “The World’s Longest Lunch” and masterclasses from international chefs with more Michelin stars than you can shake a stick at. www.melbournefoodandwine.com.au

Wildfoods Festival, Hokitika, New Zealand

Judging by the crowds that flock here every year, it seems that everyone wants to try such delicacies as wasp larvae ice cream, huhu grubs, and beer-battered beetles. There’s whitebait, venison sausages, and the like for the less adventurous, and a wide range of entertainment. Costumes are positively encouraged. www.wildfoods.co.nz

NORTH AMERICA

Vermont Maple Open House, Vermont, USA

“Sugar-on-Snow” — the pouring of boiling maple syrup onto a fresh snowfall to make taffy — is just the icing on the cake of this special weekend, when the region’s “sugarhouses” open their doors for demonstrations, events, and tastings. www.vermontmaple.org/events.php

Yuma Lettuce Days, Arizona, USA

Yuma is the “Winter Lettuce Capital of the World,” so it’s no surprise that folks here make a bit of a song and dance about all things green and good, with culinary classes, food tastings, microbrew beers, and local wines, and fun events such as ice-carving and hayrides. www.yumallettucedays.com

SOUTH AMERICA

Fiesta de la Vendimia, Mendoza, Argentina

As befits the wine capital of Argentina, Mendoza hosts the biggest and most spectacular grape-harvest festival in the land, drawing tens of thousands to the party. They come for horseback gaucho parades, music-and-light shows, fireworks displays, and, of course, delicious, robust local red wine.

From left to right Piping in the haggis at a Burns Night dinner in Edinburgh, Scotland; children throwing beans during Setsubun in Tokyo, Japan; an impressive reconstruction of the Taj Mahal using citrus fruits at the Fête du Citron, Menton, France; the “World’s Longest Lunch” at the Melbourne Food & Wine Festival

